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Acacia dealbata

Acacia dealbata, the **silver wattle**, **blue wattle**[3] or **mimosa**,[4] is a species of flowering plant in the legume family Fabaceae, native to southeastern Australia in New South Wales, Victoria, Tasmania, and the Australian Capital Territory, and widely introduced in Mediterranean, warm temperate, and highland tropical landscapes.[5]

Acacia dealbata	
Foliage and flowers	
Scientific classification	
Kingdom:	Plantae
Clade:	Tracheophytes
Clade:	Angiosperms
Clade:	Eudicots
Clade:	Rosids
Order:	Fabales
Family:	Fabaceae
Subfamily:	Caesalpinioideae
Clade:	Mimosoid clade
Genus:	*Acacia*
Species:	***A. dealbata***
Binomial name	
Acacia dealbata Link[1]	

Description

It is a fast-growing evergreen tree or shrub growing up to 30 m tall, typically a pioneer species after fire. The leaves are bipinnate, glaucous blue-green to silvery grey, and the leaves resemble those of a fern. They are 1–12 cm (occasionally to 17 cm) long and 1–11 cm broad, with 6–30 pairs of pinnae. Each pinna is divided into 10–68 pairs of leaflets, which are 0.7–6 mm long and 0.4–1 mm broad. The flowers are produced in large racemose inflorescences made up of numerous smaller globose bright yellow flowerheads of 13–42 individual flowers. The fruit is a flattened pod 2–11.5 cm long and 6–14 mm broad, containing several seeds.[3][6] Trees generally do not live longer than 30 to 40 years, after which in the wild they are succeeded by other species where bushfires are excluded. In moist mountain areas, a white lichen can almost cover the bark, which may contribute to the descriptor "silver". The Latin specific epithet *dealbata* also means "covered in a white powder".[7] The Wiradjuri people of New South Wales use the name *Giigandul* for the species.[8]

Chemistry

It has been analyzed as containing less than 0.02% alkaloids.[9] It is known to contain enanthic (heptanoic) acid, palmic aldehyde, anisic acid, acetic acid, and phenols.[10]

Taxonomy

Along with other bipinnate wattles, *Acacia dealbata* is classified in the section *Botrycephalae* within the subgenus *Phyllodineae* in the genus *Acacia*. An analysis of genomic and chloroplast DNA along with morphological characters found that the section

is polyphyletic, though the close relationships of many species were unable to be resolved. *Acacia dealbata* appears to be most closely related to *A. mearnsii*, *A. nanodealbata* and *A. baileyana*.[11]

Some authorities consider *A. dealbata* to be a variant of *Acacia decurrens*.[3]

Occurrence data from AVH

Synonyms

- *Acacia decurrens* var. *dealbata* (Link) Muller
- *Acacia decurrens* var. *mollis* Lindl.
- *Acacia puberula* Dehnh.
- *Acacia derwentii* Siebert & Voss
- *Acacia decurrens* var. *dealbata* (Link) Maiden
- *Acacia affinis* Sweet
- *Racosperma dealbatum* (Link) Pedley[2]

Subspecies

There are two subspecies:[12]

- *A. dealbata* subsp. *dealbata*. Low to moderate altitudes. Tree to 30 m; leaves mostly 5–12 cm long.
- *A. dealbata* subsp. *subalpina* Tindale & Kodela. High altitudes in the Snowy Mountains. Shrub to 5 m (rarely 10 m) tall; leaves mostly 1.5–8.5 cm long.

Cultivation

Acacia dealbata is widely cultivated as an ornamental plant in warm temperate regions of the world,[3] and is naturalised in some areas, including Sochi (Black Sea coast of Russia), southwestern Western Australia, southeastern South Australia, Norfolk Island, the Mediterranean region from Portugal to Greece and Morocco to Israel, Yalta (Crimea, Ukraine), California, Madagascar,[13] southern Africa (South Africa, Zimbabwe), the highlands of southern India,[5] south-western China and Chile.[6][14][15][16][17] It is hardy down to −5 °C (23 °F),[18] but does not survive prolonged frost.[3] It prefers a sheltered position in full sun, with acid or neutral soil. It has gained the Royal Horticultural Society's Award of Garden Merit.[18][19]

In autumn in the UK with flower buds visible

New growth

Mimosa

The flowers and tip shoots are harvested for use as cut flowers, when it is known by the florist trade as "mimosa" (not to be confused with the genus of plants called *Mimosa*). In Italy,[20] Albania, Russia and Georgia the flowers are also frequently given to women on International Women's Day. The essence of the flowers, called 'mimosa', or in older texts, 'cassie', is used in perfumes.[21]

'Kambah Karpet', a cultivar discovered at the Kambah Village

Other uses

The Ngunnawal people of the ACT and Wiradjuri people of NSW used the bark to make coarse rope and string, the resinous sap for glue or to mix with ash to make poultices, the timber for tools, and the seeds to make flour.[22][8] The timber is useful for furniture and indoor work, but has limited uses, mainly in craft furniture and turning. It has a honey colour, often with distinctive figures like birdseye and tiger stripes. It has a medium density (540–720 kg/m^3), and is similar to its close relative blackwood, but of lighter tone without the dark heartwood.

The leaves are sometimes used in Indian chutney.[3]

Invasive species

In South Africa, the species is a Category 1 weed in the Western Cape (requiring eradication) and Category 2 weed (requiring control outside plantation areas) elsewhere.[23] In New Zealand the Department of Conservation class it as an environmental weed.[24] In Spain, due to its colonizing potential and constituting a serious threat to native species, habitats or ecosystems, this species has been included in the Spanish Catalog of Invasive Exotic Species, regulated by Royal Decree 630/2013, of 2 of August, being prohibited in Spain, except the Canary Islands and the Balearic Islands, and including its introduction into the natural environment, possession, transport, traffic and commerce.[25] In Portugal, the species makes part of the official list of invasive species (along with other *Acacia* species).[26] In California, the species is invasive and appears to displace many native species, also threatening the habitat of the endangered Mount Hermon June beetle.[27][28]

See also

List of Acacia species

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